



3 Pick up your shell and press it firmly into the modeling clay. Keep it there for 30 seconds, so it leaves a distinct shape, then remove it carefully. You should see a perfect impression of the shell in the clay.



4 Now pour the plaster of Paris over the shell impression in the clay. Leave it for at least 12 hours, so that it can set hard. Remember: this bit takes thousands or millions of years for a real fossil!



5 When the plaster is set hard, ease it away from the clay. You can use your fingers to do this, but you may want to use a table knife to lever it out—in which case, ask for an adult to help you. Turn the plaster over and there's your fossil shell.

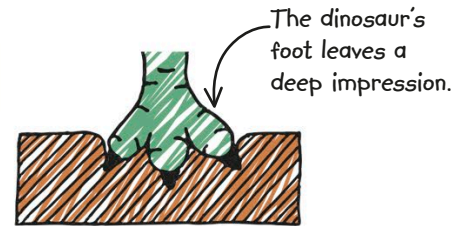
Make sure the plaster has set hard before you paint it.



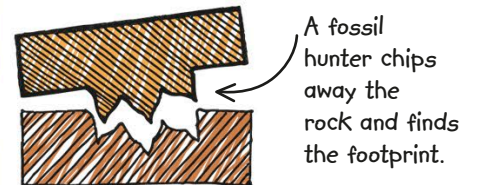
6 Paint your fossil and the surrounding plaster to make your "find" look real. Try making casts with different objects from around the home—but remember to ask the owner's permission, just in case it is something valuable!

HOW IT WORKS

Your fake fossil most closely resembles a cast fossil. This forms after the soft bits of a plant or an animal rot away, leaving a space that fills with sludge. Over millions of years, the sludge turns into solid rock. Dinosaur experts have found dinosaur footprints preserved this way.



A dinosaur leaves a footprint in soft waterside mud at low tide.



As the water rises, sludge fills the footprint, eventually making a rocky cast.

REAL WORLD SCIENCE FOSSILIZED TRILOBITE



Trilobites were sea creatures that became extinct 250 million years ago. They had a hard outer covering but no internal bones. When their soft inner parts decayed, minerals filled the spaces left behind, and fossils formed.